

Session 14: Israel's History Remixed

Key Takeaways

- Ezekiel's rhetoric intensifies as he remixes Israel's history to emphasize its true meaning.
- Israel is still in Egypt, enslaved to their idols, and God will bring them out into the wilderness of the nations. In exile they will be freed to worship Yahweh.
- The Jerusalem temple is often portrayed in a negative light, while the wilderness tabernacle is presented as the pinnacle of God's presence with his people.
- The flood and the wilderness are images of death and de-creation. They are both ways to characterize experiences that transform God's people and lead to God's new creation.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 20:1-44

Ezekiel 20:1-5

- Israel's elders come to Ezekiel to **inquire of Yahweh**

Ezekiel 20:6-29

- **20:6-9** Generation 1: **Exodus generation in Egypt**, Yahweh swears to bring them to **the promised land**
- **20:10-17** Generation 2: **Exodus generation in the wilderness**, they reject Yahweh's statutes, judgments, and Sabbaths
- **20:18-26** Generation 3: **Children of Exodus generation in the wilderness**, they reject Yahweh's statutes, judgments, and Sabbaths
- **20:27-29** Generation 4: **Children of Exodus generation in the promised land**

Ezekiel 20:30-44

- **20:30-32** Israel has been defiled by **the idols it wanted to serve (שרת)**, "and you want to **inquire of me?!"**
- **20:33-38** Yahweh swears on oath to bring Israel back into the "wilderness of the nations," purify them and enter into a covenant with them
- **20:39-44** Israel can become **a servant (עבד) to its idols** until the day Yahweh restores them, then they will worship Yahweh in a restored temple

Ezekiel 20:1-44. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

¹ In the seventh year,
in the fifth month,
on the tenth day of the month,
some of **the elders** of Israel came to **inquire** of Yahweh,
and they sat before me.

² And the word of Yahweh came to me:

³ “Son of a human,
speak to **the elders** of Israel,
and say to them,
Thus says Yahweh Elohim,
Is it to **inquire** of me that you come?
As I live, declares Yahweh Elohim,
I will not be **inquired** of by you.

⁴ Will you judge them, son of a human,
will you judge them?
Let them know the abominations of **their fathers**,
^{5a} **and say to them,**
Thus says Yahweh Elohim:

#1: The Exodus Generation in Egypt

^{5b} On the day when I chose Israel,
I lifted my hand on oath to the seed of the house of Jacob,
making myself known to them in the land of Egypt;
I lifted my hand on oath to them, saying,
‘I am Yahweh your Elohim.’

⁶ On that day **I lifted my hand on oath** to them,
that I would bring them out of the land of Egypt,
into a land that I had searched out for them,
a land flowing with milk and honey,
the most splendid of all lands.

⁷ And I said to them,
‘Each of you cast away the detestable things of your eyes,
and do not make yourselves impure with the idols of Egypt;
I am Yahweh your Elohim.’

⁸ **But they rebelled against me**,
and they were not willing to listen to me.
None of them cast away the detestable things of their eyes,
nor did they forsake the idols of Egypt.

**Then I said I would pour out my hot-anger upon them
and finish my anger against them in the midst of the land of Egypt.**

9 **But I acted for the sake of my name,**
that it should not be defiled in the eyes of the nations among whom they lived,
in whose eyes I made myself known to them,
by bringing them out of the land of Egypt.

#2: The Exodus Generation in the Wilderness

10 So I led them out of the land of Egypt,
and I brought them into the wilderness,
11 and I gave them **my statutes**,
and I made known to them **my judgments**,
which, **if a person does them, he will have life**.
12 And also, I gave them **my Sabbaths**,
as a sign between me and them,
that they might know that I am Yahweh who makes them holy.
13 **But the house of Israel rebelled against me in the wilderness**.
They did not walk in **my statutes**,
and they rejected **my judgments**,
which, **if a person does them, he will have life**;
and **my Sabbaths** they defiled.
So I said I would pour out my hot-anger upon them in the wilderness,
to bring them to an end.
14 **But I acted for the sake of my name,**
so it wouldn't be defiled in the eyes of the nations,
in whose eyes I had brought them out.
15 And also **I lifted my hand on oath** to them in the wilderness,
that I would not bring them into the land that I had given them,
a land flowing with milk and honey,
the most splendid of all lands,
16 because they rejected **my judgments**,
and they did not walk in **my statutes**,
and they defiled **my Sabbaths**;
for their heart went after their idols.
17 **But, my eye had pity on them,**
and I did not destroy them or bring them to an end in the wilderness.

#3: The Children of the Exodus Generation

18 And I said to their children in the wilderness,
'Do not walk in the statutes of **your fathers**,
and don't keep their judgments,
and don't make yourselves impure with their idols,
19 I am Yahweh your Elohim;
walk in **my statutes**,

and keep **my judgments** and do them,
20 and treat **my Sabbaths** as holy,
that they may be a sign between me and you,
that you may know that I am Yahweh your Elohim.'

21 But the children rebelled against me.

They did not walk in **my statutes**,
and they did not keep **my judgments**, to do them,
which, **if a person does them, he will have life**;
they defiled **my Sabbaths**.

**So I said I would pour out my hot-anger upon them ,
and bring an end to my anger against them in the wilderness .**

22 But I turned back my hand,

**and acted for the sake of my name ,
so it wouldn't be defiled in the sight of the nations ,**

in whose sight I had brought them out.

23 Moreover, **I lifted my hand on oath** to them in the wilderness,
that I would scatter them among the nations,
and disperse them through the lands,

24 because they did not keep **my judgments**,
and they rejected **my statutes**,
and defiled **my Sabbaths**,
and their eyes were set on their fathers' idols.

25 Moreover, I gave them **statutes** that were not good,
and **judgments by which they could not have life**,

26 and I rendered them impure through their gifts,
as they offered up every firstborn,
so that I could devastate them.
so that they might know that I am Yahweh.

#4: The Generation That Entered the Promised Land

27 Therefore, son of a human,
speak to the house of Israel,
and say to them,

'Thus says Yahweh Elohim:

In this also **your fathers** blasphemed me,
by committing treachery against me.

28 For when I had brought them into the land,
which **I lifted my hand on oath** to give them,
and wherever they saw any high hill or any leafy tree,
and there they offered their sacrifices,
and there they presented the provocation of their offering;
and there they sent up their pleasing aromas,
and there they poured out their drink offerings.

29 And I said to them,
'What is the high place (Heb. *bamah*) to which you go?'
So its name is called "Bamah" to this day.

Ezekiel's Generation

30 Therefore say to the house of Israel,
Thus says Yahweh Elohim:
Will you make yourselves impure, in the way of **your fathers**,
and go prostituting after their detestable things?

31 When you present your gifts,
and offer up your children in fire,
you make yourselves impure with all your idols to this day.
And shall I be **inquired** of by you, O house of Israel?
As I live, declares Yahweh Elohim,
I will not be **inquired** of by you.

32 What comes up in your mind,
it will never happen—the thought,
'Let us be like the nations,
like the tribes of the countries,
and worship wood and stone.'

33 As I live, declares Yahweh Elohim,
surely with a mighty hand and an outstretched arm,
and with hot-anger poured out,
I will become king over you.

34 I will bring you out from the peoples,
and I will gather you out of the lands where you are scattered,
with a mighty hand and an outstretched arm,
and with hot-anger poured out.

35 And I will bring you into the wilderness of the peoples,
and there I will enter into judgment with you face to face;

36 just as I entered into judgment with your fathers,
in the wilderness of the land of Egypt,
so I will enter into judgment with you,
declares Yahweh Elohim.

37 I will make you pass under the rod,
and I will bring you into **the bond of the covenant**,

38 I will purge out the rebels from among you,
and those who transgress against me.
I will bring them out of the land where they sojourn,
but they shall not enter the land of Israel.

Then you will know that I am Yahweh.

39 As for you, O house of Israel,
thus says Yahweh Elohim:
Go, **let every one of you serve his idols**, now and hereafter,
if you will not listen to me;
but you will no longer defile my holy name,
with your gifts and your idols.
40 For on my holy mountain,
the mountain height of Israel,
declares Yahweh Elohim,
there all the house of Israel, all of them,
they will serve me in the land.
There I will accept them,
and there I will require your contributions,
and the first of your gifts,
with all your sacred offerings.
41 With a pleasing aroma I will accept you,
when I bring you out from the peoples,
and when I gather you out of the countries where you have been scattered.
And I will display my holiness among you in the eyes of the nations.
42 And you will know that I am Yahweh,
when I bring you into the land of Israel,
the land that **I lifted my hand on oath** to give to your fathers.
43 And there you will remember your ways and all your deeds,
with which you made yourselves impure,
and you will loathe yourselves for all the evils that you have committed.
44 And you shall know that I am Yahweh,
when I deal with you for **my name's sake**,
not according to your evil ways,
nor according to your corrupt deeds,
O house of Israel,
declares Yahweh Elohim."

Ezekiel 20:1-44. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

The History of Israel's Rebellion

The leaders of the exiled community come to Ezekiel to "seek Yahweh" as if the covenantal relationship is just fine. Ezekiel sets out to tell them things are not okay between them and Yahweh (see Isaiah's similar oracle in [Isa. 1:10-17](#)).

Ezekiel sets out to reframe Israel's entire history, retelling it as one long history of apostasy and covenant violation. Each step would have shocked and offended the elders who came to him.

Israel's Rebellion in Egypt (Ezek. 20:5-9)

Yahweh's "choice" of Israel is linked to the exodus, not Abraham (20:5). Israel's idolatry began during their long stay in Egypt, serving the gods of Egypt (20:8; see [Josh. 24:14](#) and [Exod. 12:12](#)). In the Torah, it began with the golden calf at Mount Sinai, but Ezekiel discerns that the roots go deeper. Yahweh's threat to destroy Israel is located before the exodus(!) (20:9; see also [Exod. 32:9-14](#)).

The Rebellion of the Exodus Generation (Ezek. 20:10-17)

Israel's rejection of Torah and Sabbath is linked to the Exodus generation (20:13), just as the Pentateuch describes.

The plural of "my Sabbaths" (20:12-13) indicates more than the weekly Sabbath (on which, see [Exod. 20:8-11](#), [Deut 5:12-15](#)), but all of Israel's calendar rhythms shaped by the number seven which give rest, freedom, and debt-forgiveness to the land and to people from all economic classes: weekly Sabbath, Sabbatical years for the land and slaves, Jubilee year (see [Lev. 23-25](#)). Israel's entire sacred calendar is a perpetual reenactment (a "sign") of Yahweh's gracious liberation from debt and slavery.

The Rebellion of the Second Wilderness Generation (Ezek. 20:18-26)

This is Ezekiel's retelling of the generation to whom Deuteronomy was addressed, the children of the Exodus generation. Their entry into the promised land took place under Yahweh's suspended judgment (20:21-22); the exile was warned of even before they entered the land (20:23).

"The exile, on this interpretation, was not some inexplicable surprise. It was simply Yahweh blowing the final whistle after a greatly extended period of injury time."

Wright, Christopher J.H. (2001). [The Message of Ezekiel: A New Heart and a New Spirit](#). IVP Academic. 160.

Ezekiel 20:25-26 Instructor's Translation

²⁵ And additionally I gave them statutes that were no good and laws by which they could not live; ²⁶ I defiled them through their gifts—the sacrifice of every firstborn—that I might fill them with horror so they would know that I am the LORD.

This line fits with the rhetoric of Ezekiel's sarcastic revision of Israel's entire history.

- He intentionally reverses the "life-giving" Torah of 20:11, 13, 21 into "no-good commands ... by which they could not find life" (20:25). In the flow of the chapter, this refers to Israel's inability to keep the Torah and so the life-giving Torah turns into a death-dealer (compare with the same view of Torah in [Rom. 7](#); I wonder where Paul got the idea).
- Ezekiel takes the sins of Israel from his recent memory and retrojects them into Israel's origins. He accuses the wilderness generation that was given the original "law of the firstborn" (the symbolic rite in [Exod. 13:12-15](#)) of Israel's later distortion of this law into a demand for child sacrifice (which did not happen until Ahaz and Manasseh; [2 Kgs. 21:6](#) and [23:10](#)).
- Ezekiel leaves clues that the giving of these "not-good laws" doesn't correspond to any actual historical moment at Sinai. [The word for "statutes" (*khuqqim*, masculine plural) in 20:25 departs from Ezekiel's normal usage (*khuqqot*, feminine plural); also, there is no record in the Hebrew Bible of child sacrifice]

practiced before Canaanite influence on Israel during the monarchy.] The shock factor of verses 25-26 makes it clear that Ezekiel is attempting to scandalize and make his listener/reader pay attention.

- The bottom line is that Ezekiel is targeting the practice of child sacrifice by Ahaz and Manasseh in recent memory and their claim that it was the will of Yahweh. He sarcastically claims this horrible practice goes back to the Exodus generation, who thought idolatry was an acceptable practice. The entirety of verses 25-26 needs to be put in “scare-quotes” to mark its intentionally sarcastic and offensive tone.

Israel in the Land Until Exile (Ezek. 20:27-31)

Israel’s consistent idolatry and worship of Canaanite deities on the hilltop shrines (high places) is viewed as merely the latest manifestation of the nation’s enduring apostasy (20:28-31).

Ezekiel immediately shifts the blame from “your fathers” to “y’all,” that is, his audience in Babylonian exile.

Israel’s Future (Ezek. 20:32-44)

Yahweh will not allow Israel to serve idols (20:32), and he will exert his exodus-style power (the mighty hand and outstretched arm, see [Deut. 5:15](#)) to bring his kingdom to bear on his own rebellious people (20:33). He will take them on a “reverse exodus” out of the promised land and into the “wilderness of the nations” (20:35), i.e., exile to Babylon.

Exile will purify Israel of the rebellious (20:35-39) and bring them back to the land where they will offer acceptable worship in a restored temple in Jerusalem (20:40-41) and so restore Yahweh’s reputation among the nations (20:41-42).

This conclusion points forward to the oracles of hope in chapters 34 (sorting out the rebellious), 36 (enabling obedience and pure worship), and 40-48 (restoration of sacrificial offerings in the new Jerusalem).

Yahweh will do all this “for the sake of my reputation (name)” (20:44), which links back to this theme throughout the entire chapter (20:9, 14, 22).

Ezekiel's Revisionist History

“We must bear in mind the terrible task that Ezekiel faced and the rhetorical tools he chose to use. He was faced with the onslaught of the most traumatic catastrophe that had ever hit his people. And he was faced with people who were obsessed with a totally wrong interpretation of that catastrophe: that it was not really deserved at all, that Yahweh was being unfair, that it would soon be over and they would return to a Jerusalem that had yet again been delivered by Yahweh’s mighty power. The only way to counter such utter misconceptions was to shatter them ruthlessly on the hard rocks of reality, that their long history had been a ceaseless offense to Yahweh. Having seen the size of his task, we can then appreciate better his rhetorical method, which was to use deliberate parody, scathing allegory, grossly distorted caricature and overly schematic views of Israel’s history, all designed for maximum impact. Ezekiel was not writing a dispassionate chronicle of Old Testament history. He was embroiled in fierce argument with hostile or apathetic opponents. His rhetoric had to be strong and shocking enough to pierce through their armor-plated resistance.”

Ezekiel 21: Oracles About the Sword of Judgment

- 21:1-5: Parable of Yahweh's fire in the Negev forests
- 21:6-12: Yahweh's sword against the land
- 21:13-22: Song of the sword
- 21:23-27: Babylon's sword against Jerusalem and its leaders
- 21:32: Within this prediction of Jerusalem's inevitable destruction, Ezekiel brings up the messianic promise of [Genesis 49:10](#). The city will be destroyed with no messianic deliverer to interfere, until the future when "the one to whom justice belongs will come."

Ezekiel 22: Accusation Against the City of Bloodshed

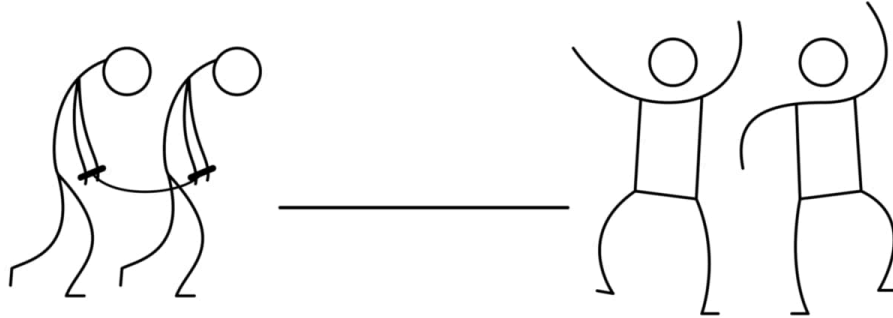
- 22:1-16: Accusation against the wicked city. Notice how Ezekiel weaves together his accusations about "religious" apostasy and "social justice" violations. In his mind these go together, as worship of the true God is distorted into idolatry, the most vulnerable of the land suffer the worst, and as the idols slowly dehumanize all parties.
- 22:17-22: Israel smelted and the dross removed
- 22:23-31: Accusation against the wicked land

Ezekiel 23: Parable of the Two Adulterous Sisters

Another allegory of Ezekiel's depicts Israel as an unfaithful wife (see [Ezek. 16](#)). In this chapter, Ezekiel develops the images concerning the northern kingdom (i.e., Samaria, Oholah "her own tent") and the southern kingdom (i.e., Jerusalem, Oholibah "my tent is with her").

Slavery in Egypt to Wilderness Freedom

EXODUS



EGYPT
SLAVES

WILDERNESS
FREEDOM

Slavery in Egypt to Wilderness Freedom. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How does Ezekiel equate his generation to the exodus generation?